Another intellectual disciple of Dignaga was Dharmapala, associated with Yogacara, an idealist ‘consciousness-only’ Mahayana school (reminiscent of the work of Edmund Husserl and Maurice Merleau-Ponty). Only the mind is real, argued Dharmapala; consciousness alone is the ultimate source of all reality. This contrasted with the doctrine ‘all is real’ held by Sarvastivada, a leading Theravada school (reminiscent of Immanuel Kant’s ‘thing-in-itself’).[18] In between these extremes—‘only the mind is real’ and ‘all is real’—stood Madhyamaka, or ‘Middle Way’, the Mahayana school associated with Nagarjuna, who posited the idea of dependent origination, implying that things do not have a fixed or an innate essence, that all sensory phenomenon exists in relationship to others, and no objective, mind-independent reality is accessible to us (reminiscent of Ludwig Wittgenstein; for more on Nagarjuna, see the chapter ‘The Void of Nagarjunakonda’).

Santideva (c. late seventh–early eighth century), a votary of Madhyamaka, focused on ethics. He famously asked:

> When fear and suffering are disliked
> By me and others equally,
> What is so special about me,
> So that I protect myself and not others?

Santideva built an elaborate argument for impartial benevolence, so that ‘each of us is rationally required to regard the welfare of anyone else as being just as important as our own welfare’, a stance strikingly similar to the utilitarian ethics of Bentham, Mill and Singer. Animals, owing to their sentience, had prominence in Santideva’s moral philosophy, and he urged everyone to be kind and compassionate to them. His radical stance nevertheless left a few blind spots in his own life—he failed to accord equal importance to the welfare of men and women.[19]

Santaraksita (c. 725–88), another interpreter of Madhyamaka, explored the thickets of the philosophy of mind, ‘the relation between cognition and the body, and the role this relation plays in causal-explanatory accounts of consciousness and cognition’. He argued with the materialist Carvakas, whose physicalism held that consciousness was nothing but an emergent property of the material body, ‘an expression of the body’s functional organization and responsiveness to a world of objects, situations, and